



The Whispers

An optional component for The Fool's Court

Taking a word

The Whispers are an **optional component**.

The 22 Whispers are shuffled face down at the start of each night. After the deal, and **before any pledge is made**, each eligible player may look at their own hand and then choose to **take one Whisper** or to go without. This becomes a new second step of the night, between the deal and the errands.

The monarch does not confide in whoever is winning. Only a player whose favour is *less* than the highest at the table may take one. On the first night of a season the whole court is level on zero, so nobody is offered a word at all.

Words and burdens

A Whisper alters how that player's favour is counted, or restricts which agents they may send out on errands, or both. Its **contents are private** and are revealed only when the night ends (except for The Watched), alongside the errands. That a player took one is plain for the table to see; *which* one is not.

Not every word is a favour. **7 of the 22 are burdens**, which cost rather than pay. A burden is framed in oxblood under a broken seal and signed as a burden, so there is no mistaking one once it is in your hand — but every Whisper is identical face down, and a player who has drawn one is under no obligation to say so.

Where a Whisper restricts errands, the restriction is optional — players may always pledge freely. However, not following the restriction means no rewards.

Because a burden is almost as likely as a favour, taking a word is a gamble: worth it when a season is slipping away, and risky when it is not. A rival who pledges strangely, or who ducks an audience they could plainly have won, is telling you something about the word they were given — and a rival who refused a free word is telling you their hand was already exactly what they wanted.

The Whispers in full

All 22 words the monarch may have for you, of which 7 are **burdens**, marked △.

WHISPER	THE MONARCH'S WORD
Blackmailed	At least one Assassin must go out. Keep your pledge for +6.
Sworn to Silence	No Assassin may go out. Keep your pledge for +3.
The Smitten	No Lover may go out. Keep your pledge for +3.
The Audited	Send two Merchants and two Fools, which pledges exactly 2. Keep it for +4.
The Debtor	A kept pledge of 2 or fewer earns nothing; keep 3 or more for +3.
All or Nothing	Keep your pledge for double favour. Break it and lose 3, whatever else you did.
The Cautious Clerk	You cannot lose favour this night, nor gain more than 7.
The Bold	+6 if your pledge is the highest at the table, outright.
The Meek	−3 if your pledge is the lowest or tied for lowest. Keep it for +4.

The Kingmaker	Keep your pledge and take +2 for every other noble who broke theirs.
The Favourite	+6 if you win more audiences than any other noble, outright.
The Wallflower	+6 if you win fewer audiences than any other noble, outright.
Sworn to the Fool	+3 favour for every audience you take with a Fool.
The Contrarian	Your pledge counts the audiences you will NOT win. Keep it for +2.
The Understudy	You are scored against the pledge of the noble on your right, not your own. Take +3 for the trouble, and +5 more if you match it.
△ The Condemned	Break your pledge and lose a further 3.
△ The Scapegoat	−2 for every other noble who keeps their pledge, to a limit of 4.
△ In Disgrace	Favour you gain tonight is halved. Favour you lose is not.
△ The Watched	Your errands are laid face up as soon as they are sent.
△ Marked for the Blade	−2 for every audience you take with an Assassin.
△ Out of Favour	A kept pledge of 4 or more earns you nothing.
△ Called Out	−5 if you win more audiences than the noble on your right.

